

Response Letter with Annotations

Freiling, I., & Scheufele, D. A. (2025). Reply to González-Bailón and Lazer: Industry control and conflicts of interest in social media research. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 122(47), e2522924122. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2522924122>

Annotations

1. Purposes

- a. Motivation: reply back to the response of González-Bailón & Lazer (2025)
- b. Specific Rationale (several bullet points)

Critic	Response	Re-response
Meta invest to absolve their platforms of responsibility	they misunderstand the results: ideological segregation in news consumption on Facebook is three times as high as segregation on the web	reliance on industry-controlled conceptualization and categorization...undermines meaningful, intersubjective peer review and the replicability
quality standards related to replicability and reproducibility	we pre-register and disclose in other documents: Replication data and code for the studies published as part of this collaboration are archived at the University of Michigan's Social Media Archive (SOMAR) as part of the Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research (ICPSR) and made available in the ICPSR virtual data	the concerns about self-interested goals of industry still exist: it's possible that Meta intentionally attenuate polarization and change the algorithm during the study duration
creation of "gated" panels of users on various platforms...Users in these "research panels" would be unaffected by algorithms that could confound research	their suggestion is not feasible: a combination of shared platform independent data collection and government-mandated data sharing (along the lines of the European Union's Digital Services Act), holds the most promise to address data access asymmetries /	

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Response Letter (~600 words)

Compared with previous reply, this response did not further discuss the possibility that González-Bailón & Lazer (2025) are “helping” Meta to absolve its responsibility for adverse effects on society or individuals. Instead, they came back to emphasize the impacts of “relying on internal Meta classifiers, concepts, and categorization methods”. Again, they proposed that researchers were unable to determine whether Meta influenced the research conclusions by merely making temporary adjustments to the platform algorithms during the research period or by modifying the data. Overall, I personally think the response is reasonable.

However, what I expect to hear more through this conversation is, what is the better or more “ethical” pattern of collaboration between academy and industry? If the involvement of industry will make the critic regarding COI unavoidable, what can the academy do to not be questioned as potentially “acting as” the PR team of industry? Does that mean we can only touch upon the “innocuous” questions (e.g., how to increase user engagement), rather than controversial issues (e.g., whether the platform causes systematic harm), when collaborating with the industry?